Standard and Poor warned that India's investment grade rating could be downgraded to 'junk' status. A senior Cabinet minister would later admit to me that the period between 2009 and 2012 were the economy's 'lost years'. 'We had an economist prime minister but the government had lost control of the economy,' says the minister.

He was right. When Manmohan Singh became prime minister in 2004, his USP was his image as an honest man and his reputation as a politician who would manage the economy well. 2G and Coalgate cast a shadow on his integrity quotient. But it was the mistakes on the economic front that really shrank his stature. He won a reelection in 2009 because the economy was growing at a healthy 8 per cent over the five-year period. The 2008 global financial crisis forced the government to relax monetary policy and introduce a fiscal stimulus to boost domestic demand. But once the fiscal deficit began to balloon from 2009 and food inflation began to rise, Dr Singh was always on the back foot. P. Chidambaram offered me an interesting, and rather candid insight: 'If we'd got the economy on the right track, nothing else would have mattered in 2014. It wasn't corruption or scams, it was the economy which destroyed us in the general elections.'

Those who met the prime minister in that difficult period in the summer of 2012 said he was looking frail and troubled. 'He was clearly a worried man, very worried. He never spoke much in Cabinet meetings in any case, now he was almost totally silent,' confessed a Cabinet minister. Another minister told me, 'He just wanted to quit, but Sonia wouldn't let him.'

Whenever two ministers would disagree on an issue, the prime minister's reflex action would be to appoint a Group of Ministers to try and evolve a consensus. At one point, these ministerial groups had swelled to as many as sixty, many of them headed by Mukherjee. 'Pranabda was now the alternative centre of power in the government. Whenever we had an issue, we turned to him for advice,' confessed a minister to me. When Mukherjee, a product of the licence-permit raj, decided to announce the much-criticized retrospective tax in the 2012 budget, the prime minister disagreed but chose not to argue (see chapter 6). The path of least resistance was now a survival ticket.